

Jonah: Running from God's Call

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Ages 10-17

Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories
Book 58 of 60

Scene 1 of 25

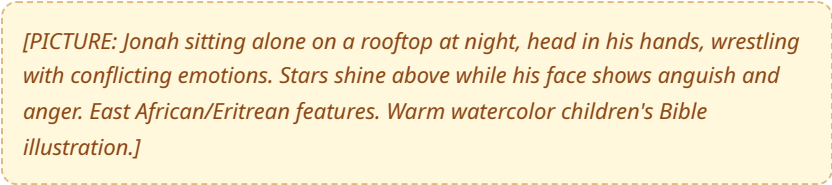
[PICTURE: A prophet standing in a sun-drenched courtyard, eyes wide as light breaks through clouds above him. His hands tremble at his sides as a divine presence fills the air. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The word of the Lord came to Jonah son of Amittai with a command that shook him to his core: "Go to the great city of Nineveh and preach against it, because its wickedness has come up before me." Nineveh was not just any city — it was the capital of Assyria, the empire that had brutalized Israel for generations. The Assyrians were known for their unspeakable cruelty: skinning captives alive, impaling enemies on stakes, and deporting entire nations from their homelands. God was asking Jonah to offer mercy to the very people who had slaughtered his countrymen. This was not a comfortable calling — it was a command that challenged everything Jonah believed about justice and who deserved God's compassion.

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Qal Egi'abher nab Yonas wedi Amitay metse: "Nabta abay ketema Nenewe kid emo antsara sbek, kif'ata ab qidmey deybu alo." Nenewe nay Asor wana ketema iya neyra — ita n'Israel n'weledotat zesaqeyet giz'at. Amlak n'Yonas n'qetelti hizbu mihrrret kihib yihato nebre.

Scene 2 of 25



Jonah's heart raged with conflict. He knew God's character — merciful, compassionate, slow to anger. That was exactly the problem. If Jonah preached and Nineveh repented, God would forgive them. And Jonah did not want God to forgive them. He had seen what Assyrian soldiers did to Israelite villages. He had heard the stories of families torn apart, of children made orphans by Assyrian swords. How could a just God show mercy to such monsters? Jonah's nationalism and his pain blinded him to a truth he wasn't ready to accept: that God's love extends beyond borders, beyond tribes, beyond the boundaries we draw around who "deserves" grace. In his mind, mercy for Nineveh meant injustice for Israel.

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Libi Yonas b'girchit teqatsele. Bahryat Amlak yifelt nebre — mihrun rihruHn denguayi qut'An. Ezi ba'lu eyu tsegem neyru. Yonas ente sebiku Nenewe ente tenesiha, Amlak k'mihra eyu. Yonas gina Amlak k'mihrom aydeleyen. Nay Asor wetehaderratt n'adtat Israel entay kem zgeberu ri'yu neyru. Fiqri Amlak kab do'bat halifu kem zikeyd kiqbel dilow ayneberen.

Scene 4 of 25

[PICTURE: A wooden sailing ship moving across calm blue waters under a clear sky. Jonah leans against the railing looking relieved, the coastline fading behind them. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

As the ship set sail and the coastline of Israel faded into the distance, Jonah must have felt a momentary relief. The further they sailed from shore, the further he felt from that terrible command. Perhaps he told himself that God would find another prophet, someone more willing, someone who didn't carry the weight of hatred for Nineveh. But you cannot outrun the One who is everywhere. Jonah's plan revealed a fatal misunderstanding — he thought of God the way pagans thought of their local deities, confined to a territory. The Creator of heaven and earth, the God who made the very sea Jonah was sailing on, cannot be limited by geography or escaped through distance.

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Merkeb mis tebegest gemagm Israel mis reHaqe, Yonas n'gzi'u irefti tesemi'wo k'kewn alewo. Kab gemgem zirehaqru, kabti zefriH ti'zaz zireHaqe tesemi'wo. Neti ab kulu bota zelo ktihadmo gina ayk'aln. Medeb Yonas abi giega ar'aye — n'Amlak kem nay ahzab amalkhti ab hade bota ziteHatsre geyru hasebe.

Scene 5 of 25

[PICTURE: A terrifying storm at sea with massive waves crashing over a wooden ship. Lightning splits dark purple clouds. Sailors cling to ropes and masts in desperation. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Then the Lord hurled a great wind upon the sea, and such a violent storm arose that the ship threatened to break apart. This was no ordinary storm — the Hebrew word used means God "threw" it like a weapon. The waves towered like mountains, the wind screamed through the rigging, and the timbers of the ship groaned under impossible pressure. Every experienced sailor aboard knew this was supernatural. The storm was God's pursuit of a runaway prophet, not to punish him, but to redirect him. Sometimes the storms in our lives are not punishments but interventions — God refusing to let us destroy ourselves through our own stubbornness and prejudice.

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Egzi'abher ke'a abi nifas ab bahri sedede, kebid ma'bel tela'le emo merkeb kitsiber qerebet. Ezi nibur ma'bel ayneberen — Amlak kem atswaar "derbeyo". Ma'belat kem akran neqwutu, nifas ab gemed cherikhe. Ma'bel nay Amlak midlay neti zihademe nebi'y nebre — n'miqtsa' zeykone n'mimilas. Hade hade gize ma'belat ab hiywetna qits'at zeykona mitit'taw Amlak iyen.

Scene 7 of 25

[PICTURE: Sailors huddled in a circle on the rocking deck, casting small stones or lots into a bowl. All eyes turn toward Jonah as the lot indicates him. Rain pelts down on them. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The sailors said to each other, "Come, let us cast lots to find out who is responsible for this calamity." They cast lots and the lot fell on Jonah. In the ancient world, casting lots was a common way to discern divine will, and God used even this pagan practice to expose His runaway prophet. The sailors bombarded Jonah with questions: "Tell us, who is responsible? What is your occupation? Where do you come from? What is your country? What people are you from?" Their questions stripped away every hiding place. You cannot hide from God, and eventually, the truth of who we are and what we're running from will be exposed — not to destroy us, but to bring us back.

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Merkebenyatat n'hadiHdom "ni'u ichi niderb izi me'at b'senki men kem zikhone nifileT" tebahahalu. Ichi derbeyu emo ab Yonas wedeqe. Amlak nezi nay ahzab limdi teTeqimu n'zihademe nebiyu qal'e. Merkebenyatat n'Yonas hithotat aznebulu — "men ikha? kabey ikha? sirahka entay?" Kab Amlak ktiHba'e ayk'aln, ab mewed'eta haqi tiqala' — n'mitfa'e zeykone n'mimilas.

Scene 9 of 25

[PICTURE: Jonah being lifted by sailors at the ship's edge, about to be cast into the raging dark sea. His face shows acceptance rather than fear. The storm swirls around them. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Jonah told them, "Pick me up and throw me into the sea, and it will become calm. I know that it is my fault that this great storm has come upon you." This moment reveals something complex about Jonah — he would rather die than go to Nineveh, yet he also wouldn't let innocent sailors die for his rebellion. The sailors, showing more compassion than the prophet himself, first tried to row back to land. They struggled against the waves but could not make it. Only when every alternative was exhausted did they reluctantly take Jonah at his word. Even in his disobedience, Jonah became a foreshadowing of Christ — one man sacrificed so that many might be saved from the storm.

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Yonas "Ali'luni nab bahri dirbiyuni emo kitHdi' iya. B'senkey kem zikhone ifelT" belom. Ezi humet b'za'ba Yonas ziteHalaleke neger yigelTs — nab Nenewe kab mikad mimat yimerTs, gina nitsuhat merkebenyatat b'senku kimutu ayfiqeden. Merkebenyatat kab nebi'y nila'li riHraHe ar'iyom, qidm nab midri kitsi'nu fetenu. Ab zeymi'zazu kelo'wn Yonas nay Kristos misale kone — hade seb tesewi'u bizuHat kab ma'bel kidihnu.

Scene 10 of 25

[PICTURE: The sailors kneeling on a now-calm deck under clearing skies, hands raised in worship. The sea is perfectly still like glass around the ship. Expressions of awe on their faces. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

They took Jonah and threw him overboard, and the raging sea grew calm. At this, the men greatly feared the Lord, and they offered a sacrifice to the Lord and made vows to Him. The transformation was instant — the very moment Jonah hit the water, the sea became glass. These pagan sailors, who began the voyage praying to false gods, ended it worshiping the true God of Israel. The profound irony: Jonah refused to preach to foreigners, yet his very rebellion became the means of these sailors' conversion. God's purposes cannot be thwarted. Even our disobedience, while it brings consequences, cannot stop God from reaching those He wants to reach. The sailors found God not through Jonah's obedience, but through his failure.

[illegible]

N'Yonas ali'lom nab bahri derbeyuwo, iti zinawets bahri hadi'u. Shi'u itom sebat n'Egzi'abher aziyom ferHu, meswa'iti aqrebulu mahla ke'a temaHalu. Lewti qitsbetagwi nebre — Yonas may mis tenkefe bahri kem mestyat hadi'u. Izom ahzab merkebenyatat nay hasot amalkhti zitslyu jemrom, n'hagenya Amlak amlikum

*wedu'u. Yonas n'wetsa'tenyatat kisebkh abiyu, ilwetu ba'la gina n'merkebenyatat nab
Amlak amtse'atom.*

*midri zeyrekebo tiHtina rekebe. "N'kentu Ta'otat zitsbeyu kab mihret yirHqu. Ane gina
b'ililta misgana meswa'iti keqribelka iye."*

Scene 15 of 25

[PICTURE: A vast ancient city with towering walls, grand temples, and bustling streets stretching to the horizon. Jonah appears tiny at the massive city gate, dwarfed by its scale. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Nineveh was an enormously important city — a visit required three days to cover it all. Its walls stretched for miles, its temples pierced the sky, and its population numbered over 120,000 people who, as God would later say, "cannot tell their right hand from their left." This was the seat of an empire built on conquest and cruelty, where human life was cheap and power was everything. The streets were filled with soldiers who had devastated nations, merchants who profited from slavery, and priests who served bloodthirsty gods. Yet God looked at this city not with the disgust Jonah felt, but with compassion. Where Jonah saw irredeemable enemies, God saw confused and lost people who had never been told the truth about Him.

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Nenewe azya abay ketema neberet — n'mibtsaH seleste me'alti yiwesd. Mendeqa n'mayiltat zitezergHe, bete meqdesa nay semay zibetiHe, hizba li'li 120,000 zibetsiH nebre — Amlak diHri'u "yemane tsegamom zeyfelTu" zibelom. Izi ab wereran chikane'n zitehantse menbere giz'at nebre. Yonas zeydihnu tsel'ati zire'ayellu, Amlak gina haqi b'za'ba'u zeytenegrom Tefi'omn tegagiyomn zelewu sebat re'aye.

*Kisem'wo abiyom kifeshlu temenye. Sibketu b'teknik mi'zuz gina b'menfes
zitebelashowe nebre — nay gize gedeb habom nay hiyewet gemed gina habe'om.*

Scene 17 of 25

[PICTURE: A great king removing his royal robes and crown, sitting in ashes wearing rough sackcloth. Citizens throughout the city streets are also in sackcloth, kneeling and weeping. Even animals wear sackcloth. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The Ninevites believed God. A fast was proclaimed, and all of them, from the greatest to the least, put on sackcloth. When Jonah's message reached the king of Nineveh, he rose from his throne, took off his royal robes, covered himself with sackcloth and sat down in dust. He issued a decree: "Let everyone call urgently on God. Let them give up their evil ways and their violence. Who knows? God may yet relent and with compassion turn from His fierce anger so that we will not perish." This was the greatest revival in recorded history — an entire city of over 120,000 people repenting simultaneously. The king's words "Who knows?" revealed humble hope rather than presumption. They didn't demand mercy; they threw themselves on it.

[illegible]

Nenewewiyani n'Amlak amenu. Tsom te'aweje, kab zi'abeye kisab zine'ase kulom keshu lebesu. Mel'ikhti Yonas n'nigus Nenewe mis betsHo, kab zifanu tensiu nigusawi kidanu awtsi'u keshu lebisu ab Hamed teqemeTe. Awaj awetse: "Kulu b'hitsuTs nab Amlak yitseli. Kab kifu'e mengedomn ametsom yimelesu. Men yifelT? Amlak temelisu

*b'mihret kab nediru qut'a'u yimles nihna ke'a ayniTef'in." Izi ab tarikh zitemezbege
zi'abeye nisiha nebre — milu'e ketema b'hade gize tenesiha.*

Scene 18 of 25

[PICTURE: Golden light breaking through clouds over the city of Nineveh. Citizens look up with tearful, grateful faces. The atmosphere has shifted from darkness to warmth and peace. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

When God saw what they did and how they turned from their evil ways, He relented and did not bring on them the destruction He had threatened. God's mercy triumphed over judgment. The Creator of the universe looked down at these former enemies of His people — brutal warriors, idol worshipers, practitioners of unspeakable cruelty — and He saw their broken hearts. He saw tears streaming down the faces of soldiers who had finally confronted their own wickedness. He saw a king humbled in ashes who once sat in arrogance. And God's heart was moved. This is the scandal of grace: it goes to those who don't deserve it. But then again, no one ever has. Grace, by definition, is undeserved — or it wouldn't be grace at all.

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*Amlak zigeberwo mis re'aye, kab kifu'e mendedom kem zitemelsu mis re'aye,
teHasasibu neti zeferariHom Tif'at ayewredomn. MiHret Amlak ab li'li firdi te'awete.
FeTari alem nezom nay hizbu tsel'ati zinerbu — chekanat wetehaderratt, amlekhti
Ta'otat — temelkete emo sibur libom re'aye. Ab gets wetehaderratt nib'at re'aye. Ab
Hamed zitewaredde nigus re'aye. Libi Amlak tetenkefe. Izi nay tsega miskan eyu —*

*nab zeybeqi'u yikeyd. Gina zibeqi'e fetsimu ayneberen — tsega zeygibu'e sle zikhone
tsega yibhal.*

Scene 19 of 25

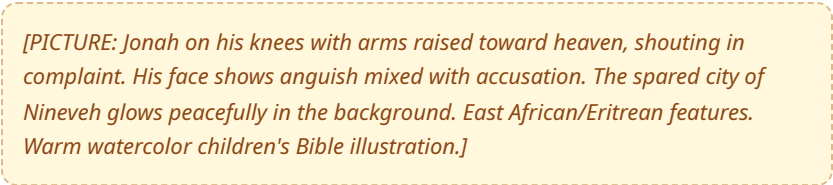
[PICTURE: Jonah sitting outside the city walls, face contorted with rage, fists clenched. Behind him the city of Nineveh is peaceful and spared. His body language radiates fury and frustration. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

But to Jonah this seemed very wrong, and he became angry. He was greatly displeased. Let this sink in: God just performed the greatest act of mass salvation in the Old Testament, and His prophet was furious about it. Jonah wasn't angry because God failed; he was angry because God succeeded. The mercy Jonah feared had come to pass. The enemies of Israel would live. The people who had tortured his nation would be forgiven. Jonah's rage exposes something ugly that lives in many of us — the belief that some people are beyond redemption, that certain enemies don't deserve a second chance. His anger reveals that he valued his hatred more than God's compassion, his nationalism more than divine love.

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N'Yonas gina izi azyu Himaq koynu tesema'yo emo teqoTe. Azyu hazene. Izi Hiseb: Amlak ab bluy kidan zi'abeye nay midhan tegbar fetseme, nebiyu gina b'senku nedere. Yonas Amlak sle zifesehe zeykone sle zite'awete teqoTe. Iti ziferiHo mihret tefetsimu — tsel'ati Israel kinebru iyom. Qut'a Yonas abana'wn zelo Himaq neger yiqali' — gele sebat kab midhan wets'a'i iyom zibl imnet. N'tsil'u kab riHraHe Amlak n'biherawinnetu kab fiari Amlak nila'li agemiTwo.

Scene 20 of 25



Jonah prayed to the Lord: "Isn't this what I said, Lord, when I was still at home? That is what I tried to forestall by fleeing to Tarshish. I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in love, a God who relents from sending calamity. Now, Lord, take away my life, for it is better for me to die than to live." This is perhaps the most shocking prayer in Scripture. Jonah quoted the very attributes of God that should bring comfort — grace, compassion, patience, love — and used them as accusations. He turned God's goodness into a complaint. "I knew you'd do this!" he essentially said. Jonah would rather die than live in a world where his enemies received the same mercy he enjoyed. His prayer reveals the darkest corner of religious prejudice: using theology to justify hatred.

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Yonas nab Egzi'abher tseleye: "Goytay, gena ab adey keleku zibelkwo izi diyu aykonen? Slezi nab Tersis kihadem qedime fetenku. Tsegawn miHrun zidengu qut'an b'fiqri milu'en kab Tif'at zimles Amlak mikwanka ifelT neyre. Hiji Goytay hiyewetey wiseda, kab minbar mimat yiHaysheni." Izi ab qidus tsiHuf zi'abeye zesdemm tselot

*kikewn yik'il. Yonas tsega, riHraHe, ti'gisti, fiqri — bahryat Amlak kem kisi
teTeqimulom. TsibuQnet Amlak nab Tir'an qeyrwo. Tsel'atu kem zibele'e mihret
ziqebblulu alem kab minbar mimat meriTsu.*

Scene 21 of 25

[PICTURE: Jonah building a small shelter of branches on a hillside east of the city. He sits in its shade, arms crossed, staring at Nineveh with bitter expectation, waiting to see what will happen. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

But the Lord replied, "Is it right for you to be angry?" Jonah went out and sat down at a place east of the city. There he made himself a shelter, sat in its shade and waited to see what would happen to the city. God asked a simple question, but Jonah didn't answer — he simply left and found a vantage point to watch. Part of him still hoped God would change His mind and destroy Nineveh anyway. He sat like a spectator at an execution that had been cancelled, still hoping for violence. This is what prejudice does to a human soul: it makes us prefer destruction over reconciliation, judgment over mercy, death over life — as long as it happens to "those people." Jonah had become the very thing he hated: someone devoid of compassion.

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Egzi'abher gina "miquTa'i qinu'i diyu?" ilu melese. Yonas weTsi'u b'mibraaq ketema teqemeTe. MeTsel'i seriHu ab Tsilalu teqemiTu n'ketema entay kem zikhona yir'i nebre. Amlak qelil hito hatete gina Yonas aymelesin — weTsi'u zir'i bota deleye. Gena Amlak hasabu qeyru n'Nenewe keTif'a tesfa nebero. Kem te'azabi nay zitesereze

*qits'at kof bele, gena n'inwet tetsbiyu. Adlwo n'nefsi seb kemzi yigebra — kab irqi
Tif'at, kab mihret firdi, kab hiyewet mot nimerTs — n""itom sebat" kisab zikhone.*

Scene 22 of 25

[PICTURE: A lush green vine growing miraculously fast over Jonah's shelter, providing cool shade. Jonah smiles for the first time, comfortable and content under the broad leaves. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Then the Lord God provided a leafy plant and made it grow up over Jonah to give shade for his head, to ease his discomfort, and Jonah was very happy about the plant. Notice: this is the only time in the entire book that Jonah is described as happy. Not when God saved him from drowning. Not when God gave him a second chance. Not when an entire city repented. Jonah was happy about a plant — about his own comfort. God "provided" this vine just as He had "provided" the great fish. God was setting up an object lesson, a parable in real time. He was about to use a simple plant to expose the twisted priorities of Jonah's heart: comfort for self mattered more than compassion for 120,000 souls.

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Egzi'abher Amlak hanti tekhli adalyu ab li'li Yonas abqwele, n'ri'su tsilal kihbo tsebeba'u keqellelu. Yonas b'ita tekhli azyu teHagose. Astebhil: izi ab milu'e metsHaf Yonas Higus kikewn zitegeltselu inko gize eyu. Amlak kab mist'am kidHino kelo aykonen. Kal'ay idol kihbo kelo aykonen. Milu'e ketema kitinsaH kela aykonen. Yonas

b'tekhli teHagose — b'nay geza'e ri'su michot. Amlak neza tekhli "adalewe" kemti "asa zedalewe" — nay libi Yonas zitebelashowe qedamnet n'miqila'i timhirti yiser'i nebre.

Scene 23 of 25

[PICTURE: A withered, dead vine with a small worm at its base. Jonah sits exposed to a scorching sun and hot east wind, face red with heat and anger, shaking his fist at the sky. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

But at dawn the next day God provided a worm, which chewed the plant so that it withered. When the sun rose, God provided a scorching east wind, and the sun blazed on Jonah's head so that he grew faint. He wanted to die and said, "It would be better for me to die than to live." God asked him, "Is it right for you to be angry about the plant?" "It is," Jonah said. "And I'm so angry I wish I were dead." Three times now Jonah preferred death — rather than go to Nineveh, rather than see mercy succeed, and now rather than lose a plant. His sense of proportion was completely destroyed by his bitterness. A plant that lived for one day mattered more to him than a city of human beings. This is what unforgiveness and prejudice do: they distort our values until we care more about our comfort than others' very existence.

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N'ts'bahitu ab wegah'a gina Amlak hanti hasekha adalyu neta tekhl'i bel'a hareret. TseHay mis wetset Amlak ziHarir mibraqawi nifas sedede, tseHay ab ri'si Yonas nededet dikheme. Kimewt delyu "kab minbar mimat yiHaysheni" bele. Amlak "b'senki tekhl'i miquTa'i qinu'i diyu?" hateto. "Iwe" bele Yonas "kisab mot kiquTa'i qinu'i eyu."

*Seleste gize Yonas mot meriTsu — nab Nenewe kab mikad, mihret mi'wat mis re'aye,
hiji ke'a tekhli mis motet. MiHret zeymigbarn adlwon ab libi seb kemzi yigebir —
wagatatna kem zizab'u yigebir.*

*mi'itin isran shiH seb yemane tsegamom zeyfelTu — bizuHat inssa dima zelewwa
kidnigtselaa ayigba'in?" Megot Amlak b'qelalinetu zesdemm nebre. Yonas n'zeyfetera,
zeytekela, zeydekemela tekhli hazenela. Kindey nila'li Amlak n'zifeterom hizbi yigdes!
MiTqas inssa nay Amlak aTeqalali riHraHe yigelTs — miHretu nab kulu hiyaw fiTur
yizirgaH.*

ayigba'indo?" Izi kifut mewed'eta ilamu tsbuQ eyu. Hito n'Yonas Tiray zeykone n'akha eyu. N'kulu gele hizbi kab fiqri Amlak wets'a'i ilu zihasebe seb eyu. N'geza'e ri'sna tsega n'kali'ot firdi zideli kulu eyu. Amlak nay mewed'eta qalu abzi metsHaf hito eyu — libna n'mir'ay b'qin'ina kinmilso yideli: mihret Amlak n'kulu mikwanu b'haqi niamndo?

Discussion Questions

1. Jonah's prejudice against the Ninevites was rooted in real pain — they had genuinely harmed his people. Does having a "valid reason" to dislike a group make prejudice acceptable? How do we distinguish between healthy boundaries and sinful prejudice?
2. Jonah wanted grace for himself (rescue from the fish) but judgment for others (destruction of Nineveh). Can you identify areas in your own life where you accept God's mercy freely but resist it being extended to people you dislike or distrust? What does this reveal about our understanding of grace?
3. God called Jonah to go to people he hated. Have you ever felt God calling you toward someone or a group of people you'd rather avoid? What makes it so difficult to show love to those who have hurt us or who are different from us?
4. The book ends without telling us whether Jonah ever changed his heart. Why do you think God left the ending open? What is the author trying to accomplish by leaving Jonah's response unresolved? How does this open ending make the story personal to each reader?
5. In today's world, we see divisions based on ethnicity, nationality, religion, politics, and social class. How does Jonah's story challenge modern tribalism? If God asked you to show compassion to a group your community considers

"the enemy," how would you respond — and would your response look more like Jonah's or God's?

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Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

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